Learning Meta Commands In psql With Rideshare

When connecting to PostgreSQL you'll need a client application. GUI applications are great, but in this book you'll work solely from your Terminal and run the psql client that comes with PostgreSQL.

psql is recommended for several reasons. To learn more about the thinking behind recommending psql, refer to the Appendix "Why psql?"

To start, type psql with the --dbname option specifying the Rideshare development database:

sh/psql_dbname.sh
```
psql --dbname rideshare_development
```

A backend process ID corresponds to your psql session. Run SELECT pg_backend_pid(); to see the value.

The command above doesn't set the host of the server, or any user, password credentials, or a connection string URL. If the command doesn't work as-is, review the "Development Guides" Appendix. Make sure you're able to easily connect to your running PostgreSQL database server before proceeding.

With that out of the way, you're now staring at a blank psql prompt. Now what?

Try typing \s and hitting Enter. This might be the first *meta-command* you've used if you're new to psql. psql has loads of meta commands. Some are listed in the post *17 Practical psql Commands*[1] and you'll see a lot of them here. This meta-command lists the history of SQL statements or commands you've run in psql before. If you run a statement like SELECT 1; and then run \s again, you'll see the statement in the history.

Administration Terminology



- Meta Commands — psql commands that start with a backslash
- Backends — A backend process with a pid and query
- System Catalog — A PostgreSQL table or view you might use to inspect internal state information

In the same way the history command works in your Terminal, you can do a "reverse search" through your commands by typing "ctrl-r". After typing ctrl-

1. https://www.postgresqltutorial.com/postgresql-administration/psql-commands/